





GIRLS' CLUB (clockwise from left) A still from *Four More Shots Please!*; a poster of *Adulting*; a still from *Fabulous Lives of Bollywood Wives*; and (bottom) a poster of *Girls Hostel*

ENTERTAINMENT

THE FRIENDS WE NEED

There are now enough web shows about ***female friendships*** *for them to be a radical, subversive genre unto themselves*

Back in 2020, when producer Rangita Nandy called ad filmmaker Joyeeta Patpatia to helm season three of *Four More Shots Please!* (FMSP), Patpatia admitted that she hadn't seen the series. But so popular was *FMSP*, she knew enough to join some dots. As Patpatia began her month-long preparation—watching 20 episodes, each lasting at least 30 minutes—she empathised with the Mumbai-based female quartet of Damini (Sayani Gupta), Siddhi (Maanvi Gagroo), Umang (Bani) and Anjana (Kirti Kulhari). It helped that she is part of a quartet herself. "When the show dropped, there was a gap in content that celebrates female friendship. We had seen a lot of movies, but most of them were male-led or seen from the gaze of a man," says Patpatia. "For the first time, we were seeing the mindset of urban, independent and progressive women."

FMSP (2019—) arrived at a time when the big screen had seen films like *Lipstick Under My Burkha* (2016) and *Veere Di Wedding* (2018) release. YouTube, on the other hand, had seen its share of sisterhood-centric shows with Bindass's *The Trip*, The Viral Fever's (TVF) *PA-Gals* (2017-18) and *Girls Hostel* (2018—), and with Dice Media's *Adulting* (2018-21). But it was *FMSP's* style quotient, scale and subsequent success that drove other OTT platforms to develop more shows that looked at female friendship in all its hues.

TVF's roster now includes *The Interns* (2020—) and its latest mini web series *Sisters* (2022—); ZEE5's Zindagi vertical released Pakistani web series *Churails* (2020), and one of Netflix's most popular originals is *Fabulous Lives of Bollywood Wives* (2020—), a show about a real-life girl gang comprising Seema Khan, Neelam Kothari, Maheep Kapoor and Bhavana Panday.

For Shreyasi Sharma, the creative head of TVF's YouTube channel 'Girliyapa', it was never just about the

